well against Sweden. He and Steve McClaren just built us up slowly towards Friday night's game against Argentina in Sapporo.

That week, we even got a little break from the kind of strict diet that's part of being in a training camp these days. I have to own up: it was the best idea I had all summer. We'd been away from England—and away from fast food—for three weeks already. And I was starting to miss the occasional burger and fries. I assumed there'd be a few of the other lads feeling the same way. I talked to Sven, who thought it wouldn't do any harm, and then had a word with the England chefs. On the Wednesday night we all trooped down to dinner. The doors of the dining room were shut and there were two giant golden arches stuck up on them. We all went inside and there was a McDonald's takeaway mountain waiting for us: more burgers, cheeseburgers and chips than you've ever seen piled up in one room in your life. It was a complete surprise to all the players. We just devoured everything: it was like watching kids going mad in a candy store. And it worked. We did it again before we played Denmark. Maybe fast food was what was missing from our preparations for facing Brazil.

With England, we always do a lot of work on the other team. It's the job of Dave Sexton, a United manager back in the seventies, to talk us through our next opponents. He'll discuss each player in a twenty-odd man squad. Then he'll show us a video that picks out that player: this is what he does when they're attacking; this is what he does when they're defending. Dave will then explain exactly what he thinks we should be doing to counter what that player can do. It's almost like planning a military operation. That kind of work with players is being done more and more in soccer. Everybody seems to have the latest technology now. Instinctively, I'm a bit old school. I'd just like to go out and play. But I understand the importance of knowing your opponents' strengths and weaknesses inside out. A tiny advantage is often all you need to win a match at the top level.

It goes without saying: we couldn't wait for Argentina. The prospect of the next match was what shook us out of the depression after the draw with Sweden. I really admired how the lads prepared themselves for a game against the World Cup favorites. Self-belief is such an important element in soccer. Argentina were one of the best teams in the tournament. Every England player went into the match convinced we were going to beat them. There was that strength of mind in every individual, and through the team as a whole. In hindsight, that draw against Sweden had made it simpler for us: we went out on the Friday night knowing we had to get a result.